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CAMBRIDGE IGCSE • FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH • 0500

What Changes *in 2027*

A teacher's briefing on the new 0500 exam: what is different, what it means for your classroom, and what to do this term.

- ◆ Both papers at a glance
- ◆ Classroom actions for each change
- ◆ Five ready-to-use lesson starters
- ◆ The six changes that matter
- ◆ Year 10–11 planning map
- ◆ Department meeting checklist

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SECTION 1

The new exam at a glance

Two written papers, each 2 hours and 80 marks, each worth 50% of the grade. Some centres enter candidates for the Coursework Portfolio (Component 3) instead of Paper 2.

Paper 1 · Reading *three texts, about 1,400 words*

Question	Text	Task	Marks
Q1	A	Comprehension: explicit and implicit meaning (tests all five reading skills)	20
Q2(a)	B	Selective summary, max 120 words	15 (10R + 5W)
Q2(b)	B	New: writer's attitudes and opinions	5
Q3	C	Short answers, including 2-mark word meanings (key words in bold)	10
Q3	C	Language task, 200–250 words	10
Q4	C	Extended response (letter, report, journal, speech, interview or article), 250–300 words	20 (10R + 10W)

Paper 2 · Directed Writing and Composition

Question	Task	Marks
1(a)	New: structured question on 1–2 texts (550–650 words): analyse and evaluate ideas, including how the writer influences readers	5
1(b)	Directed writing: speech, letter, article or report, 250–350 words	35 (10R + 25W)
Section B	Composition: one of four titles (two descriptive, two narrative), 350–450 words	40

Six changes that matter, and what to do

1 Paper 1 has four equal questions

What it means: Q1–Q4 are each worth 20 marks. Students who spend too long on the early questions will lose the most at the end.

Do this: Teach “marks = minutes”. Run a timed session where students must move on when the timer sounds, then compare the Q4 answers with untimed ones.

2 Q1 tests all five reading skills

What it means: Comprehension is no longer only retrieval. Inference and explanation questions sit alongside “give” and “identify”.

Do this: Label every Q1 practice question as SAYS (explicit) or SUGGESTS (implicit) before students answer. Knowing the type tells them how to answer.

3 A new summary question, 2(b)

What it means: Five marks for identifying a writer’s attitudes or opinions and explaining how we can tell.

Do this: Drill one structure: attitude + evidence + brief explanation. Use opinion columns and editorials. Ten minutes a week is enough.

4 Word meanings are worth 2 marks

What it means: Key words appear in bold. With two marks available, a vague one-word answer may not be enough: students need a precise meaning that fits the context.

Do this: Teach the swap test: put your meaning back into the sentence. If it does not fit exactly, refine it.

5 Shorter writing targets

What it means: Language task: 200–250 words. Q4: 250–300 words. Directed writing: 250–350 words.

Do this: Shorter means selection matters more. Practise cutting a 400-word answer down to the target without losing marks. It forces students to prioritise.

6 Paper 2 now assesses evaluation of how writers influence readers

What it means: Question 1(a) asks students to analyse and evaluate the texts directly, and the reading marks in 1(b) reward evaluation over repetition.

Do this: Build a “repeat → use → develop → evaluate” ladder into every directed writing lesson. Give students texts with deliberately weak evidence to question.

A Year 10–11 planning map

One way to sequence a two-year course so that every question type is taught, practised and revisited before the exam.

Term	Reading focus	Writing focus
Y10 Autumn	Q1 explicit/implicit; word meanings in context	Descriptive composition: senses, structure, imagery
Y10 Spring	Q3 language task: Choose → Zoom → Connect	Narrative composition: story mountain, show don't tell
Y10 Summer	Q2(a) summary and Q2(b) attitudes	Directed writing forms: letter and article
Y11 Autumn	Q4 extended response in all six forms	Directed writing forms: speech and report; 1(a) evaluation
Y11 Spring	Full Paper 1 mocks, timed	Full Paper 2 mocks, timed
Y11 Summer	Targeted revision from mock data	Targeted revision from mock data

Five lesson starters for the new questions

Says or suggests?	Show five Q1-style questions. Students sort them into explicit and implicit in two minutes.
Swap test	One bold word in a sentence. Students write a meaning, swap it in, and vote on which meanings fit exactly.
Attitude in 3	Read one paragraph of an opinion piece. Write one sentence: attitude + evidence + explanation.
Spot the weak evidence	Show a persuasive paragraph with an unsourced statistic and a single anecdote. Students name what is missing.
120-word squeeze	Give students a 160-word summary. They cut it to 120 without losing a single point.

Department meeting checklist

☐ Everyone has read the 2027–2029 syllabus
 ☐ Old past papers flagged as “old format”
 ☐ Mock papers rewritten in the new format
 ☐ Mark schemes updated for 2-mark word meanings and Q2(b)
 ☐ Paper 2 lessons include explicit evaluation
 ☐ Students told which Paper 2 route they are taking

READY-MADE RESOURCES

Save hours of planning

If you'd like the practice material done for you, every PassWithPurpose resource is written for the new 2027 format, with original texts and full mark schemes:

Complete Exam Guide	The method for every question on both papers, with model answers and timing plans
Paper 1 Practice Pack	Three full Paper 1 papers: nine original texts, question papers and mark schemes
Paper 2 Directed Writing Pack	Four Section A tasks with 1(a) questions and annotated model answers
Composition Pack	Descriptive and narrative toolkits, 20 titles and four model compositions

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